What just happened: An Explanation of the First Degree

Text in red in keeping with our ritual books is the suggested wording and floor directions.
Text in Blue who will be delivering and the duration.
Text in Green audience participation.
Text in Purple Narrator

WM - 🔨 🔨 🔨 Item……...on our agenda is **What just happened? - An Explanation of the 1st Degree**. Brother Junior Deacon, (pause while JD Stands) Please prepare the candidate

JD replaces wand in holder and prepares the Candidate in the South -West ensuring he leaves keys or coins to be divested later

WM- I invite W/ Bro Narrator to the Podium.

Prologue (Delivered by Narrator) – 5 min

Acknowledgement: The following is only one interpretation, and does not represent the definite explanation of the First Degree, as our research widens, we will in cooperate updates and amendments as necessary.

Despite all the research and analysis, by learned historians and eminent Masonic researchers, no one can say for certain the origins of Modern Freemasonry or its interpretation. What we can all agree is: During the period in which speculative Freemasonry grew, there was a culture of clubs, more specifically "themed" clubs. The 17th and 18th centuries were awash with them.

Regarding the spirituality of Freemasonry. One must remember that, the early church builders were priests and monks, so automatically any ritual references would have had a spiritual edge. If you read the works of some famous Masonic scholars, one will realise just how complex and personal this is. For example, W.L. Wilmshurst, you find a deeply esoteric perspective. JSM Ward and Rev. George Oliver take a more Christian approach. Whereas Rev James Anderson famous for compiling the 1723 Book of Constitutions and the Traditional Histories, traces the Crafts origins to Adam, Euclid, Pythagoras, and Moses, as does Albert G Mackey.

Bob Cooper makes this point in his 2002 paper in *Ars Quatuor Coronati* 115: *None of the 'Traditional Histories' of any of the branches of Freemasonry are, or were, intended to be taken literally. Our forebears in all the Orders manufactured suitable 'pasts' for allegorical purposes. They did so with romantic notions at heart but understood that these histories were not literal truth.*

The real beauty of our craft, and probably the most important thing to remember, is its universal appeal, and it's very personal connection, open to interpretation by the individual. With one aim, despite our varied backgrounds to make us better men, dedicated to helping each other and mankind.

In order to give a balance interpretation, we have incorporated a mix of Operative Masonry, and Speculative Freemasonry which we practice, together with the Spiritual meaning, the following has been compiled from Solomon, and from the analysis by

masonic researchers Wilmshurst, Ward, Sandersons, Anderson, and The Lectures of the Three Degrees in the Craft to name a few, the other references are listed in our Bibliography.

The Three Degrees in Freemasonry represent the Physical, Mental and Spiritual aspects of our being. Today we will examine the Physical aspect, the First Degree commonly known as the Ceremony of Initiation.

The ceremony of Initiation represents the Birth of Man. As an Entered Apprentice Freemason, we learn three lessons: Wisdom, Strength and Beauty.

The Initiation is broken down into two Acts – "**State of Darkness"** and the "**State of Light"** these can be further broken down into 16 distinct scenes. As per your Program

States of Darkness

1. The Preparation – JD
2. The Admission to the Lodge – IG
3. The Three Challenges – Chaplin
4. The Prayer of Dedication - Chaplin
5. The Mystical Journey (or Perambulation) – Secretary / Treasurer
6. The Declarations of Freedom, Motive, and Perseverance – SW
7. The Advance from West to East – JW
8. The Obligation – W/M
9. The Restoration to Light - W/M

State of Light

10. The Revelation of the Greater and Lesser Lights – Deputy Lodge Mentor
11. The Three Great Dangers – SD
12. The Entrustment with the Secrets – Open to any brother
13. The Testing by the Wardens – ADC
14. The Investiture with the Apron - SW
15. The Instruction in the North East – DC
16. The Instruction in the Working Tools – IPM

Presentations

1. The Presentation of the White Gloves - JW
2. First Degree Tracing Board – Open to any Brother
3. Epilogue – Narrator

The State of Darkness - We are all born blind or hoodwinked and as the ancients taught, our quest on earth, after fumbling around in pain, sorrow and ignorance was to ascend to the Halls of Light and Truth, *"the truth that will set us free".* Only after numerous trials do we refine and purify our soul.

For now, the candidate has to make his way to the entrance of the Halls of Light.

Narrator – Russell - Act One- State of Darkness, Scene One- The Preparation to be delivered by Bro JD

WM - 🔨 🔨 🔨 "Bro Deacons"

JD brings Candidate from the South- West to directly in front of the Senior Wardens Pedestal, then waits until SD has Joined him and the candidate, JD steps out Salute and presents. SD then takes a step back from the Candidate.

1. **Preparation** (Delivered by Junior Deacon)

{Humorous Anecdotes along the lines of Brethren did you wonder what the hell is going on a strange man half strip you asked you to expose your left breast removes your belt and robs you of all your possessions} ...well here's Why

The preparation of the candidate should have begun long before the ceremony, by his proposer and seconder, who should instruct him on what is expected of a Freemason, and by carefully observing his character and disposition.
On the day of the ceremony, he is lead to a quiet anteroom and left alone to compose his mind. He is then prepared by the Tyler as follows:

Divested of all metallic substances and monies: (remove keys or coins)
Firstly, no weapons of "*defensive or offensive"* should be brought into the Lodge, so as not to disturb the harmony of the lodge, as it is consecrated ground and therefore holy. Secondly, all men are on the level, their status and wealth have no bearing in the lodge, and before the Supreme Being. They are judged by their moral worth as men. The candidate demonstrates he is ready to renounce material wealth in exchange for spiritual wealth. This also alludes to the later part of the ceremony where his benevolence is too be tested.
And thirdly the temple was a place of peace and silence so noise could be produced by the use of metal tools, 1st Kings 6:7 tells us that *"Neither hammer or axe nor any tool of iron"* was used in building Kings Solomon Temple.

The right arm was made bare, (hold up arm). The obligation was taken on the Cubic Stone or Altar. It was essential therefore nothing manmade came between the skin and the Stone of the Altar, to allow the spiritual energy contained in the holy writings to be transmitted pure and unsullied to the initiate.

The left breast was made bare, (point to) not only to ascertain his sex, but to allow the point of the poniard and the compass to be felt against his heart a symbol of sincerity. The left side of the body being deemed weaker than the right, he knelt on his **bare left knee** (point to) **in** symbolic weakness, before the altar in contact with Mother Earth, a sign of respect and deference.

Slipshod - (point to) It has been said that the reason for this harks back to the time when Moses received the ten Commandants from God on Mount Sinai, *"put off thy shoes for the ground that thy stand is holy".* But this does not explain why the candidate enters the Temple wearing one shoe.

The removal of one shoe was a method of legalising transactions or contracts, which was an old Israelite custom: (Ruth 4:7) tells us "*Now this was the custom in former times in Israel concerning the redemption and the exchange of land to confirm any*

matter: a man removed his sandal and gave it to another; and this was the manner of attestation in Israel".

The candidate by giving up his shoe is entering into a contract with the brethren of the Lodge, the Craft, and the Supreme Being.

Cable Tow Placed About my Neck: (Hold)
The Cable Tow, being a symbol of bondage and death born out of ignorance, is placed round his neck, not only to control his movements, but demonstrate his humility on his being a slave to false doctrines. The cable tow is a sign of the Candidate Pledging his Life in Service to the Craft.

Finally Hoodwinked (JD places Hoodwink on the Candidate)
First, as symbol of being in darkness before birth.

Second, to focus the candidates mind, to free him from visual distractions as he enters the lodge for the first time. "*So that his heart might conceive before my eyes should discover"*

Third, to test and create the candidate's full reliance, and trust, in those whom he cannot see, and almost certainly cannot know.

And lastly if he, the candidate decides not to take the obligation, he leaves the lodge without seeing its members or the layout of the lodge.

Salutes WM

Narrator –Act One, Scene Two the Admission and Entrance to be delivered by W/Bro
Both Deacons move towards the door of the Lodge and turn with backs to the lodge door. DC places kneeling stool and then sits.

2. Admission into the Lodge (Delivered by Inner Guard)

Salutes WM

The Candidate entering the Lodge in the North-West Symbolises him coming from the darkness into the light, as all those unbaptised were buried in the North West part of the cemetery where the sun did not shine.

His entrance is via three knocks- **Why three knocks?.....(Ask the Audience)** – This is in allusion to scripture Matthew 7:7, **First knock** (actually knock for dramatic effect) *"ask and it shall be given",* **Second Knock** (actually knock for dramatic effect) *"Seek and you will find*" and the **Third Knock** (actually knock for dramatic effect) *"Knock and the door will be open to you".* "The three separate knocks of an E.A. symbolise that in the uninitiated man, Body, Soul and Spirit are all at variance".

The Inner guard tells the Worshipful Master, that the Candidate seeks the privileges of Freemasonry '*by the help of God, being free and of good report'*. It was once the case, and still is, that a belief in God and being a free man, not a serf, or in bondage, is a requirement before being apprenticed to a trade.

This appears to be taken from Operative Lodges, under King Edward III Regulations for the Trade of Masons (1356) no slave could be accepted as an apprentice the

Regulation states *"That no one of the said trade shall take the apprentice or journeyman of another, to the prejudice or damage of his master, until his term shall have fully expired".*

A belief in a Supreme Being was obviously necessary in order to take a solemn obligation on the Volume of the Sacred Law (in our case the Bible).

The Worshipful Master then sends out his Messengers, his Deacons, bearing wands of power, top with a Dove, an emblem of peace, fidelity and love.

The Senior Deacon represents the link between Spirit and the Soul.
The Junior Deacon Represents the link between the Soul and Mind and it is for this reason he takes the lead in this ceremony.

Salutes WM

Narrator –Act One, Scene Three and Four - The Three Challenges and the Prayer of Dedication will be delivered by W/Bro

3. The Three Challenges: (Delivered by Chaplin)

Salutes WM

W/Bro Jim Wheeler walks on to the floor and approaches Deacons by the door- IG presents the Poniard and holds it up

The First Challenge is the poignard presented to his naked left breast, he is asked *"if he feels anything?"* **Why is this? .....(Ask the Audience)** To demonstrate an awareness that he is entering on something serious and solemn, and does so in a measured manner when directed and not rashly or in haste. For If he had, the poignard would be stained with his blood, hence the reason the inner guard holds it up, visible for all to see.

The path of spiritual life is suffering, and the journey begins with the threat of death and ends with death.

JD and SD escort candidate to the edge of the carpet in front of kneeling stool

The Second challenge WM asks *'Are you Free and of mature age?*' as already stated if the candidate was already an apprentice, or in servitude, he could not become an apprentice freemason.

The other requirement he had to be "of mature age" to have the ability to fully understand what he was entering into. Traditionally the age was 21 in keeping with the law of the land. After assuring the Worshipful Master and the brethren, the Candidate is asked to kneel.

JD and SD bring the candidate to the kneeling stool, **WM –** 🔨 🔨 🔨 Candidate kneels sign of reverence, Wand crossed JD in front of SD

4. The Prayer of Dedication (Delivered by Chaplin)

The deacons form an inverted V above the candidate, with their wands, which has several significant interpretations. The formation of a Heavenly Arc, for the Holy Spirit to descend, to guide and protect the Candidate on his journey. In ancient civilisations the triangle was seen as rebirth, more specifically in operative masonry the crossed wands emphasise the compasses.

This simple brief prayer is the initial act of the Ceremony, to spiritually bind the candidate to his Lodge, and the great brotherhood, and to endow him with Wisdom, Strength and Beauty. It is important to note that this is a prayer for the candidate and the craft, not just over him. Therefore, every brother should unite with the Chaplin with the intention of uniting the candidate with the craft.

The Third challenge which happens later after the Prayer of dedication, is; '*In whom do you put your trust'*. This was to confirm his earlier declaration by his own lips in front of a Lodge of witnesses, a belief and reliance in a Supreme Being. It was said in some records that candidate was not prompted, and had to answer freely, if he failed to give the correct answer he was removed from the lodge.

Salutes WM

Narrator –Act One, Scene Five - The Mystical Journey or perambulation to be delivered by W/Bro

JD lifts candidate from kneeling stool together with SD. DC removes kneeling stool returns to DC chair. Deacon's line up in the north-west corner of the carpet.

5. The Mystical Journey (or Perambulation) (Secretary/ Treasurer)

Salutes WM

There are several parts to this explanation the first is for the Candidate, then for operative masons and finally speculative Freemasonry us the brethren.

The Worshipful Master announces North, East, South and West why?

The North has always represented a place of darkness and inhospitable conditions which represent our profane world of ignorance. So, it is only fitting that his entrance is in Darkness, a poetic dramatization of his birth out of complete darkness both spiritual and physically.

The Candidate places his trust in God and his Leader, and is told to step off with his Left foot. The left foot, more importantly the left side, in antiquity was where the heart resides, which is a symbol of ones will, emotion and consciousness. Egyptian and Hindu gods are often depicted with their left foot foremost which has a dual meaning, the crushing under foot of evil, and associated with new beginnings. Horus and Krishna, and then later by the Archangel Michael Crush the serpent or Satan with their left foot. So likewise, the Candidate steps off crushing his ego under the left foot.

JD instructs candidate in a whisper to step off with left foot slowly, toward the East SD following behind- stop and turn on the right Tassel when narrator says *"Guide all your actions"* SD resumes his seat. JD and "Can" remain still

During the Perambulations around the Lodge the candidate, is asked to stop and turn in each corner, corresponding to the four tassels on the carpet or tiles representing the four virtues, *"Let Prudence direct you, Temperance to chasten, Fortitude support you, and Justice to guide all your actions"*.

The position of the Tassels by the Master's right represents Justice and that on his left Temperance.

JD steps off with candidate with Left foot to left tassel stops and turns remain still

The right of the Senior Warden represents fortitude (point) and that on his left prudence (point).

Part Two of the Explanation – Operative Masonry and Brethren

The Candidate is then paraded around the lodge in the prescribed manner, to be examined. In the early days of Operative masonry, the candidate had to be *"a Fit and proper person*" he should be able bodied having all his limbs able to walk with unequal healing, there should be no residual signs of shackles or bondage and no impediments. We would like to point in Speculative Freemasonry these restrictions are no longer in place and all are welcomed into our ranks.

JD instructs candidate in a whisper to steps off with left foot slowly towards the JW and stops to the left

In the original ceremony, before dedicated lodge rooms were built, the Candidate would have walked between the table and benches amongst the brethren, and approached the Wardens from behind and would knock three times on their right shoulder.

JD holding candidate right hand firmly strikes the JW on right shoulder thrice with candidate right hand

So, it was only natural for the Wardens to enquire*; JW says "whom have you there?".* It is also important to note that the floor of the lodge was considered Holy and the candidate was not permitted to walk there until he had been cleared by the Wardens to *JW "Enter Free and Good Report".*

Today's Ceremonies are conducted in purpose-built Temples, the candidate approaches from the front. Why three Knocks on the right Shoulder? (JD knocks JW on right shoulder 3 times) **.....(Ask the Audience)**

The right side of the body is associated with desire to be with God

The Junior Warden represents the Sun, and spiritually the *"Mind"* and is the symbol of Beauty the first lesson.

JD instructs candidate in a whisper to steps off with left foot slowly towards the 3rd Tassel, stops and turns

The Senior Warden represents the celestial body the Moon, and spiritually the *"Soul"* and is the symbol of Strength the second lesson.

JD instructs candidate in a whisper to steps off with left foot towards SW, strikes the SW on right shoulder thrice with candidate right hand in time to Ask To seek and to Knock

So just as the Tyler knocked three times, *"to Ask"*, *"to Seek, and to Knock*" on the physical barrier, the door of the lodge. The candidate now knocks three times on the MIND (point to JW) and SOUL (point to SW) as a request for them to be opened for him, to receive the Light of Life and Wisdom, the last lesson of the degree.

In the early ceremony the candidate was required to speak directly to the wardens so that they could judge his sincerity and spiritual status. Socrates said to one of his students *"Say something, that I may see you".*

Salutes WM

Narrator– Act One, Scene Six - The Declarations of Freedom, Motive, and Perseverance to be delivered by W/Bro

JD instructs candidate in a whisper to steps off with left foot slowly towards the SW and stops to the left of SW

6. The Declarations of Freedom, Motive, and Perseverance (Delivered by SW)

Salutes WM

JD leads candidate north of the SW pedestal, reverses and presents candidate to SW. SW elevates candidate right hand with fingers out stretched

After the Wardens are satisfied, the Senior Warden presents the candidate to the Worshipful Master for initiation.

It is said, but I am unable to substantiate the following; when the Senior Warden presents the candidate, he elevates his right hand displaying all his fingers, as it was common practice in Europe to cut off the little finger of slaves.

Also, in certain cultures – particularly Japanese – payment of a debt, or atonement for one's wrong doing, was made by the cutting off of the little finger. Just another way to prove the Candidate is a free man.

Before the initiation can proceed the Worshipful Master poses a series of questions to the Candidate, which he is expected to answer with candour. This is to satisfy the WM and the brethren that the Candidate:

SW hands back candidate to JD, take up position to the left and in front of the SW pedestal waits on the carpet

1- Was Seeking spiritual enlightenment voluntarily, for his own sake, and not for any material motive or gain nor had been coerced by others seeking to profit from him.

2- The object of his seeking was firstly a thirst of knowledge for his personal benefit, and secondly to benefit mankind by virtue of that newly acquired higher knowledge. It is important to note, that the candidate must first educate himself in the ways of the Craft, only then is he is motivated to live a life of genuine Masonic service to humanity. marked by unselfishness, without being tainted by glory or gain, attached to his charitable deeds.

3- He pledged to preserve the tenet of the Craft, not only during the ceremony of his Initiation, but throughout his daily life from this moment forward.

Again, during those early days of freemasonry, the questions should be answered spontaneously without prompting, for they involved a personal commitment, with far reaching implications, which no one should pledge himself lightly or under persuasion.

The candidate would have been prepared by his sponsors indirectly, through careful crafted conversations.

Only after the Worshipful Master is assured then he instructs the Senior Warden to direct the Junior Deacon to instruct the Candidate to advance to the Light. It is worth noting that in the early form of the ceremony if the Worshipful Master or Wardens were not satisfied that the candidate was genuine, the ceremony would come to an end, and the candidate asked to leave the lodge.

Salutes WM

Narrator– Act One, Scene Seven - The Advance from West to East to be delivered by W/Bro

7. The Advance from West to East (Delivered by JW)

Salutes WM

After completing his odyssey around the lodge, which alludes to his wanderings on this Earth, in a state of figurative poverty and distress, ignorant to the light, he has passed blindly, but never without guidance, and is beckoned to the Light, by three steps, ***Why Three*? What is special about the number three?.....(Ask the Audience)**

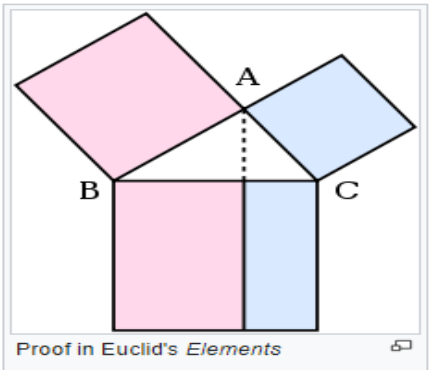
Three represents the Divine and is said to be a perfect number: past, present and future; birth, life, and death, Harmony, Wisdom and Understanding. The Number Three appears repeatably in Freemasonry: 3 Degrees, 3 principal officers, 3 Great Lights, etc.

JD instructs candidate in a whisper to steps off with left foot slowly towards the pedestal and stops three paces away.
JD instructs candidate in Taylors to advance to the pedestal. JD then instructs the candidate to take three steps backwards. JD instructs candidate in Emulation to advance to the pedestal. “Place your feet together, then to turn out your right foot as to form a square. Take a short pace with left foot bringing the heels together in the form of a square. Take another, a little longer, heel to heel as before, another still longer heels together as before”. SD joins the JD in front of the pedestal

One explanation for the three irregular steps, is they are a depiction of the irregular nature of all man’s steps. It is only after he has taken his obligation and the *“Light”* has been bestowed on him, then and then only, does his steps become regular.

The Lectures on Freemasonry states the irregular steps consist of Right Lines and angles which teach Upright lines and well squared actions. In some early forms of the ceremony, particular in the States of America, the distance of the steps is reversed starting with the longer paces.

In America a distance of 15, 12 and 9 inches is prescribed for each step which is also used in the construction of the three sides of Pythagoras Triangle, as defined by Euclid 47th Problem please see your program for the diagram, which states. *"In any right triangle, the square of the two sides connected to the right angle is equal to the square of the third side called the hypotenuse".*



Proof in Euclid's *Elements*

If you recall the Junior Deacon instructs the candidate *"Place your feet together then to turn out your right foot as to form a Square"* the formation of a right angle, the varying lengths, represent the varying lengths' of Euclid's Triangle.

Thus, arriving at the formation of three squares, the fourth comes later, being on or at the Pedestal or Altar, alluding to the Hebrew tetragrammaton, the four letters Y.H.W.H, Yod-He-Vau-He, the sacred name, of the one whom the candidate will later seek *"Yahweh"* in ancient Hebrew*, or* in English *"Jehovah".* We know this from *Cornelius Agrippa (1486-1535) in his book The Occult of Philosophy which states "four squares are ascribed to God the Father"*

Brethren, I give it to you? Is this not a cryptic clue? the journey starts in allusion to the sacred name and points to the final step of "Pure and Antient masonry" the Royal Arch?

The Worshipful Master represents the Spirit and the Light, Will power, Experience and Wisdom. And is the symbol of Wisdom the third lesson.

The Worshipful Master after reciting the qualifications required, and informing him of the *"great and invaluable privileges" available "to worthy men"*. Have you ever wondered Brethren what exactly are those *"Invaluable privileges"?* ***can anyone tell me.....(Ask the Audience)***

They are spiritual, knowledge of oneself, instruction on how to live happy with one's brother's and neighbours, in service to humanity and the Supreme being. And Membership of Fraternal organisation where everyone is equal, treated with respect and dignity.

He is further informed that *"vows of fidelity are required* ", and finally will he promise to *"keep inviolate the secrets and mysteries of the Order"* to which the candidate must give his unprompted ascension. It is at this point the candidate can refuse to continue, hence why he must answer of his own volition.

Worshipful Master then directs the candidate to take his obligation on the Three Great Lights of Freemasonry held on the Altar.

WM instructs Candidate to kneel on his bare Left knee in symbolic weakness, his right foot formed in a square, as previously explained forming the last square alluding to the last letter in the sacred name "H". JD instructs Candidate to kneel Right foot in a square etc

He is supported by the Word and Light of the Great Architect by this bare right hand on the Volume of the Sacred Law. The Master instructs him to support the *compasses "one point presented to his naked left breast"*. What does this imply?

The Lectures on the three degree tells us this is seen as a "torture" *"As this is a torture to your flesh, so may it ever be to your mind and conscience if ever you should attempt to reveal the secrets of Masonry unlawfully."*

The Deacons wands form a Triangle over the Candidate representing the arc of heaven the request for Gods Holy Spirit.

Deacons' Cross wands JD wand in front of SD wand

Salutes WM

Narrator –Act One, Scene Eight and Nine- The Obligation & The Restoration of Light to be delivered by W/Bro

8. The Obligation - means to tie or bind one to another (Delivered by WM)

In the ancient tradition of many Monastics Orders and secret societies, the Obligation was seen as a way of protecting the Trade Guilds privileges and secrets. But as we are Speculative Craft the Solemn Obligation takes on a deeper meaning.

Its main purpose is to impressed on the Initiate the path of Light, Knowledge of oneself, and the extreme value of silence to enable the new perceptions of light and wisdom to come to him and elevate his heart and mind. He carefully listens to the Master and repeats in a conscious and solemn manner. And thereafter only speaks when prompted.

The initiate is asked to identify himself by his full name before the Great Architect, and the assembled brethren, and to affirm that he does so under his own volition, with a pure heart and mind, "*sincerely*". That he will never reveal the secrets and mysteries of Freemasonry, the exception being to a Freemason who is well versed in the craft. He will never write those secrets in any format, or on any medium.

It is important to note that the obligation is not a legally binding by today's interpretation, but harks back to the time when a man's honour was bound to his pledge, it is a moral bond made by him to his brothers, The Craft and before the Supreme Being.

If the initiate breaks that bond by either writing the secrets or revealing them then he disgraces himself as a man, becoming a "*wilfully perjured individual*, *void of all moral worth"*

9. The Restoration to Light (Delivered by WM

After Sealing his Obligation with his lips why? It is thought to have come from Proverbs 24:26 "*Whoever gives an honest answer kisses the lips*". In medieval times in Scotland, contracts and pledges were not legally binding until the signer added an **X** representing Saint Andrews Cross to the end of the contract and then proceeded to kiss the cross to prove his sincerity.

Deacons' lower wands

The Worshipful Master then asks the Initiate *"after being kept for some considerable time in a state of darkness, what in your present situation is the predominant wish of you heart*?"

The statement "*Considerable Time*" is not in reference to the duration the initiate was wore the hood wink, but rather the considerable time he has spent in darkness from his birth till now.

In the very early ceremonies, the Master would pronounce *"let Light be given to him at the third blow of my Gavel*".

(WM raises gavel and makes the sign of the Cross while saying the following)

We cannot substantiate this but in modern ceremonies the Worshipful Master makes the sign of the cross, as a both a blessing and protection to the new made brother at the moment he is blessed with the "Light"

JD removes Hoodwink Initiate remains kneeling if comfortable with Deacons at either side

When the Hoodwink is removed, the candidate head should be held in such a position that the first thing he sees is the three Great Lights. **Brethren What are they?.....(Audience)**

Narrator - Next Act State of Light

WHAT JUST HAPPENED: AN EXPLANATION OF THE FIRST DEGREE

The State of Light

STATE OF LIGHT

10. The Revelation of the Greater and Lesser Lights – Deputy Lodge Mentor
11. The Three Great Dangers – SD
12. The Entrustment with the Secrets –
13. The Testing by the Wardens – ADC
14. The Investiture with the Apron - SW
15. The Instruction in the North East – DC
16. The Instruction in the Working Tools – IPM

Presentations

1. The Presentation of the White Gloves - JW
2. First Degree Tracing Board -
3. Epilogue - Narrator

Narrator –- Act Two- State of Light, Scene One- The Revelation of the Lesser and Greater Lights to be delivered by W/Bro

10. The Revelation of the Lesser and Greater Lights (DLMentor)

Salute WM

The Three Great Lights:
The Initiate is kept kneeling whilst the Worshipful Master reveals the three Great Lights, it is only fitting therefore; he should receive these divine truths with humility and reverence.

Volume of the Sacred Law- (Point to) Is the embodiment of God's Divine Law, which encompasses physical, intellectual, and moral law. It is refreshing to note that those early Freemasons were mindful that the Bible was not the only expression of God's Divine Law, and the Bible was permitted to be substituted by any Holy Scripture from any creed or religion.

The Compasses, (Point to) first: In operative masonry, the compasses, were used for measurement of the architect's plans and proving proportions. In speculative masonry, it is symbolic of that true standard of rectitude, which alone can bestow happiness. Hence, the compasses are an emblem of skill, knowledge and restraint. The only true measure of a Freemason's life and conduct.

Spiritually, the compasses resting on the Volume of the Scared Law represent the Holy Spirit and the Arc of heaven, the Divine principle manifesting from the Supreme Being.

The Square (Point to) **–** in speculative freemasonry is an emblem of honesty, truth, morality and fairness, and is set opposite too, and conjoined with, the compasses. Spiritually the Square can also represent stone, and the earth, a vessel of cosmic matter, and the compasses the arc of heaven. So, when combined, the Divine spirit

takes form, and symbolise God's creation of heaven and earth. And when combined with the Volume of the Sacred Law, create a tripartite symbol that reminds us of the three symbolic degrees of body, mind and soul. The points of the compasses being hidden by the square, implies that man's immortal spirit, his Divine aspect, is prevented from manifesting, by his human nature.

SD returns to seat JD "wheels new brother (NB) around to the WM Left leaving room for the first regular step

The Three Lesser Lights are revealed to the Initiate as the Sun, (point to) the Moon (point to) and the Master (point to). The Masonic Lodge, is seen as a microcosm of the world, which the candidate, has circumnavigated his life, with the aid of a spiritual guide, and been reborn. So, it is only fitting to incorporate the sun and moon,

No Lodge can operate without a Worshipful Master, who represents God the creator, he calls the Lodge into being and opens the Lodge.

Ward in his Book **the Entered Apprentice Handbook** gives a wonderful depiction of this and I quote;
"*In India this aspect of God the creator, has been individualised as **Brahma**... It is the Master who opens the Lodge, who calls it out of nothing. He sits in the East, the place of light; but though he opens, he does not close the lodge. That is the work of another aspect of the Divine Being.*

In the nature of man, the Worshipful Master (point to) *represents the Spirit, the Divine Spark within us, ever striving for the light….*

The Senior Warden (point to) *represents the setting sun, and hence the destructive, or transformative, aspects of the Deity. **Shiva**. The Senior Warden closes the Lodge. As the Destroyer, he reminds us that Death, the great leveller, will bring all men low, and his symbol is the Level……. But in the nature of man, the Senior Warden represents the soul, which alone enables the Spirit to raise the body towards divine things. Without the medium of the soul, the spirit would be unable to influence the body. It is for this reason that the initiate is invested in craft masonry by the Senior Warden or soul, and not by the Worshipful Master.*

The Junior Warden (point to) *represents the sun at its meridian. He stands for the way of life, the balance between birth and death…... He calls us from labour to refreshment and from refreshment to labour. In the divine aspect he represents the preserver, called **Vishnu** in India. **Vishnu** is associated with the element of water and with corn, and his caste mark is a perpendicular, straight line, referring to the rain which falls from heaven. This symbol is remembered in our lodges by the plumb rule. In the nature of man, he stands for the body, and the Mind which perishes"*

To sum up; the revelation of the **Three Great Lights,** is to reveal to the Initiate the Basic Law and Principles of the Great Architect of the Universe. Whilst **the Lesser Lights** constitutes his first lesson *"knowledge of himself"* and teaches him that those Principles exist also within his own soul, and provide him with lights sufficient to shape it into perfection and bring himself into harmony with cosmic law.

Salute WM

Narrator – Act Two- State of Light, Scene Two- Three Great Dangers to be delivered by W/Bro

11. Three Great Dangers (Delivered by SD)

Salute WM

The Initiate is then reminded of the two great dangers he has already escaped, by his "*meek and candid behaviour*" he is shown the poniard, to serve as a warning of the great danger of rushing unprepared into any spiritual venture, and the wisdom of heeding counsel before advancing.

While the cable tow JD removes cable tow and hands to speaker reminds him and us, that the divine spark may be extinguished by materialism if we do not persevere steadfastly.

But there was a third danger the Worshipful Master continues, having his "*throat cut across*", (SD, JD and new brother (NB) EA sign and cut), "*His tongue torn out by the root* and his body was then "*buried at low water mark, or cable's length from the shore where the tide regularly ebbs and follows twice in twenty-four hours*".

The symbolic penalty associated with the First Degree, is based upon a real legal punishment. One well-fitting those who divulged state secrets, or acted outside their authority. Records in the 15th century and beyond detailed the horrific punishment for any municipal officer who disclosed, '*the King's counsel, his fellow's, or his own'… he was bound hand and foot to a stake set upon the seashore where the tide ebbed and flowed, his throat was cut, and his tongue torn out through the slit'.*

• "*Having his throat cut across*", was an act normally restricted to the slaughter and sacrifice of animals, not men.

• "*Tongue torn out by the root* is symbolic, of removing the instrument of falsehood used to take, then break, a solemn oath; It also implied that he was unable to speak for himself in the afterlife.

• Garbage was disposed of by allowing it to rot and decay a cable's length, which is 600 feet from the shore. Because he had dishonoured himself in life, by revealing or writing those masonic secrets, his body would be dishonoured and regarded as garbage. Leaving the body to decay and be consumed by fish, crustaceans, birds, and insects, condemned his soul by denying him an 'afterlife'; perhaps the most dreadful punishment of all.

Not being buried on consecrated ground would mean his spirit would not rest, and wander endlessly. To abide with the change in the law, when capital punishment was abolished, the Initiate is very relieved to hear that the "*Inclusion of Such a Penalty is unnecessary*".

The sign now takes on a mystical meaning, if the new mason violates the secrets entrusted to him, he is cutting off the higher self (SD, JD and new brother (NB) EA sign and

cut) This also alludes to the throat chakra, responsible for communication, and self-expression, so figuratively *"the tongue torn out by the root".* Hence preventing any further progress in cosmic truths, so he might as well be "*buried in the sand of the sea"* and left to rot spiritually.

The Initiate is then made aware that there are "*several degrees in Freemasonry*" which he can only attain through "*merit, and abilities*". It is worth noting, that merit comes first and is one of the key messages of the Provincial Mentoring Lodge, that a brother who zealously works for this Lodge and the Craft, regardless of his ability to learn the ritual should be encouraged and supported in his journey, through the Offices of the Lodge with a view of occupying the Masters Chair.

The Worshipful Master directs the newly made brother to stand perfectly erect, Psalm 112:4 tells us "*Unto the upright there arises light in the darkness; He is gracious, and full of compassion, and righteous".*

The pillar like posture, is known to be conducive to focus the mind on spiritual attainment, hence why all masonic prayers are conducted standing.

The Worshipful Master then directs him "your feet formed in square" *as "the rectitude of your actions"* which means to focus his mind on his righteous actions. Then "you will now take short pace towards me with your left foot bring the right heel into its hollow"

JD NB feet formed in square ensures the new brother follows these directions

Geometrically our new made brother transforms from a square to a Tau Cross, originally a phallic symbol, which is the emblem of generation and creation.

The First Regular Step simply put, is if we do not control our passions, we cannot hope to advance towards true knowledge of the Great Architect of the Universe. Hence, we trample our passions and egos under the Tau Cross.

The Entered Apprentice is then shown the sign associated with this degree and its historical connection with the obligation of the degree and the third great danger.

Salute WM

Narrator – Act Two- State of Light, Scene Three- The Entrustment with the Secrets to be delivered by W/Bro

12. The Entrustment with the Secrets (Delivered by Open)

Salute WM
WM demonstrates the Grip with the assistance of the JD

The *"Grip*" or *"Token*" is then communicated to him. It is interesting that both words are used, grip meaning "to take a firm hold" and token means an "exchange or gift" in this case, the gift of brotherly affection.

The *"Grip*" most probably is the earliest form of secret communication. As operative masons travelled to building sites around the country or even abroad, they were able

to communicate their membership and rank within the Guild with a handshake, without having to go through a long examination of their skills. Similarly on meeting fellow Masons and when attending Lodges, they were able to identify themselves and their level as a Freemason.

The Grip or token was made more secure by the addition of a word.

The word is *"Boaz".* Who was Boaz?..... **(Ask the Audience)**
Boaz was a *'a mighty man of wealth'* and of charity, he owned vast amounts of farm-land, and at harvest time according to Israelite tradition, he would allow the poor to glean the corn that had fallen from the hands of the harvesters.

One of these unfortunate souls was the poor widow Ruth, who supported her widowed mother-in-law, Naomi by gleaning in the fields. Boaz learning of her compassion for Naomi, was moved to make special arrangements for Ruth, to be shielded from molestation in the fields by the young men, by leaving a *'ephah of grain'* which was the daily amount of grain for a person, at a designated place so she did not have to spend all day in the fields.

Scriptures goes on to tell us, that Boaz, went on to purchase all the land Naomi's late husband and sons had sold, and to marry Ruth, so that their family name and property would not be lost.

How did he do this? Ruth 4:7-15 tells "*Now this was the custom in former times in Israel concerning the redemption and the exchange of land to confirm any matter: a man removed his sandal and gave it to another; and this was the manner of attestation in Israel".*
8. So the closest relative said to Boaz, "Buy it for yourself." ***And he removed his sandal****.*

The union between Boaz and Ruth produced the royal line of Kings, David, whose son was Solomon, and then many generations later Jesus Christ.

In recognition of the strength, charity, and honourable character of his great-great grandfather, King Solomon dedicated the left-hand pillar of his magnificent temple to Boaz. 2nd Chronicles 3:17 tell us *"Behold, and he raised up the pillars before the temple, one on the right hand and the other on the left and called the name of that on the right **** and that upon the left Boaz".*

The name Boaz in Hebrew when halved "Bo" means "In", "az" means "to be Strong", so by halving the name Boaz the Entered apprentice derives a deeper understanding of the name.

Salute WM

Narrator – Act Two- State of Light, Scene Four- The Testing by the Wardens to be delivered by W/Bro

13. The Testing by the Wardens (Delivered by ADC)

Salute WM

JD leads new brother to Junior Warden pedestal and presents him

Following the entrustments with the secrets, our newly made brother is led to the Body and Soul the Junior and Senior Wardens to be tested. **Why?..... Ask the Audience**

In the past few Operative masons were literate, the work was passed down orally and by hours of practise. There were no Blue or Red Books.

In keeping with operative and speculative Freemasonry, a limited test of the Entered Apprentice intelligence was conducted, twice. To ascertain if he, can retain that "*Light"*? Is he still striving to tread the path and to take the *"step"*? Does he still exhibit the *"sign"* of a true Mason? Does he remember, and act upon the *"word"* that was given him"?

In some early versions of the ceremony, the Worshipful Master says to the new Brother "*arise, Brother Boaz, and salute the Junior and Senior Wardens as such, and convince them that you have been regularly initiated as an Entered Apprentice Mason, and have got the sign, grip, and word."* Once again, we find in these early rituals examination by the Wardens required the brother to answer unprompted, as a test of his memory and understanding.

The practise of lettering or halving a word not only served to preserve its secrecy, but to protect the Mason if he was unsure if the person, he was in communication with, was truly a Freemason. With the additional benefit of reinforcing the word in his mind.

JD leads Presents Brother to Senior Warden

Salute WM

Narrator - Act Two- State of Light, Scene Five- The Investiture with the Apron to be delivered by W/Bro

14. The Investiture with the Apron (Delivered by SW)

Salute WM

WM: 🔨 🔨 🔨 "Bro SW, I delegate you to invest him with the distinguishing badge of an Entered Apprentice Freemason"

DC brings Apron on Cushion returns to seat

As previously mentioned, the Senior warden is responsible for the investiture of the *"Badge*" for he represents the soul which stimulates the Spirit, which in turns, motivates the body to higher aspirations.

Operative masons used aprons to protect themselves and their clothing from the rough stone. In **speculative freemasonry** the apron is also seen as symbol of labour, and hence why it should be removed when the lodge is called from labour to refreshment.

The newly made Brother is told "*it is more ancient than the Golden Fleece or Roman Eagle, or any order in existence"*. This may refer to the Golden Fleece from Greek Mythology dating back to the 3rd Century, but more likely refers the Order of Chivalry called The Order of the Golden Fleece founded by Philip, Duke of Burgundy in 1429. Where knights of the Order were appointed by Royalty. The Roman Eagle dates back to 100 B.C.E. and is the highest emblem of dignity, honour, and power.

The main thing to take away and focus on from the aforementioned, is the honour and glory the "*Badge"* bestows on the wearer, and his duty to maintain those very high standards, and traditions, hence the warning that comes later.

The apron is made of white Lambskin, both the colour and the animal are emblems of purity, and innocence, respectively. White lambs were chosen as a sacrificed to God.

The shape of the apron is an equilateral triangle superimposed on a rectangle. The triangle represents the Spirit, and the rectangle the body, SW invests new made brother with Apron. the two are tethered to the body by two cords which should be worn on the navel.

Which represents the bodies energy centre, for this reason the apron should be worn on the navel to bring balance to the wearer. The white lambskin apron is a symbol of the perfection of body and purity of mind.

The Entered Apprentice apron, was originally worn with the flap turned up (SW turns up flap), indicating that, as with the square and compasses, that the Spirit has not yet conquered the physical body. The raised flap is also said to represent Fire indicating that the blessing of material light has been restored to the wearer enabling "his eyes to perceive much of our symbolism This practise still occurs in some Lodges, and the flap remains up until they have taken their next step.

This practise still occurs in some Lodges, and the flap remains up until they have taken their next step.

It is important to note that the knock given during the Senior Wardens address *"Never disgrace that (Slap/ Clap) **Badge"*** is not only to reinforce the warning but is a reminder to listen the inner voice of conscience.

The Worshipful Master, then instructs the new brother and reminds the brethren of what is probably the most important of all masonic etiquette, how to resolve issues between brothers, and preserve the bonds of Harmony and Fraternal Union.

Salute WM

Narrator - Act Two- State of Light, Scene Six- The Instruction in the North East to be delivered by W/Bro

15. The Instruction in the North East (Delivered by DC)

Salute WM

The Worshipful Master then directs the link between the soul and mind, the Junior Deacon, to place our newly made brother at the north-east corner of the Lodge. Why?..... **(Ask the audience)**

(JD leads New Brother to the North East, right foot across the lodge left foot down the lodge, SD joins)

Firstly, the laying of the Cornerstone in the north-east in operative masonry, was for practical reasons allowing the stone mason to work following the sun and thus making use of all the daylight.

North-East spiritually is the meeting of dark and light associated with the bringing of spiritual power, mental clarity and with the Spring Equinox, in medieval churches it was also the symbolic tomb of Jesus. On an individual level it symbolises the darkness, and the light, which reside in us all.

The Worshipful Master proceeds to tell the Entered Apprentice, that he is figuratively, and spiritually the cornerstone of the lodge.

The importance of this statement has to some extent been lost in modern times. The laying of the cornerstone was accompanied by impressive ceremonies often with dignitaries in attendance. The cornerstone of any building was the most important stone, as all other stones were set in reference to that stone, the whole building integrity rests on the accuracy of the cornerstone. So similarly, the future of our whole masonic structure rests on the Entered Apprentice Freemason.

That moment for many Entered Apprentice's, myself included, is a source of great pride, then the encouragement to "*to raise a superstructure perfect in is parts and honourable to the builder".* The superstructure referred to is his spiritual body, perfected in its parts by allowing the builder the Great Architect of the Universe to permeate his being.

The Worshipful Master informs the brother, after expounding the virtues of charity, and dispelling the belief that all speculative Freemasons are from rank and opulence. A reminder of those operative masons, who work hard for their living, often away from their families for extended periods, sometimes meeting with accidents or misfortune.

JD To step out in front of new brother with plate

He is asked "*have you anything, to give in the cause of charity"* in some Lodges the candidate is not prompted to answer he must answer on his own volition which is then followed by *"If you had not be so deprived would you give freely"*

JD steps back

Our newly made brother has to make a choice, armed with the word Boaz, and symbol of strength, compassion and charity, at the junction of Darkness and Light, will he slip back into darkness or will he use the strength of Boaz and advance into the light.

On affirming his benevolence, the Master then proceeds to explain the test, and the importance of charity as the distinguishing characteristic of a Freemasons heart, especially towards each other.

From everything we have learnt, why would the ceremony have to be repeated "*if he had neither money or metallic substances about you"* why?**..... (Ask the audience)**

Answer: The cornerstone had to be perfect, as we have seen metal and or money are seen as impurities to be discarded when entering the lodge for initiation. So, he *"if had any money or metallic substances about him*", it would render him as the figurative cornerstone impure, imperfect and he, the stone would have to be rejected, *hence "the ceremony of you Initiation thus far, must have been repeated".*

Salute WM

Narrator - Act Two- State of Light, Scene Seven- The Instruction in the Working Tools to be delivered by W/Bro

16. The Instruction in the Working Tools (Delivered by IPM)

Salute WM

JD leads brother in arc directly in front the working tools

On successfully passing the test, our newly made brother is lead to and endowed with the working tools that he will need to get the next phase. In operative masonry he now has the tools to start to prepare a rough ashlar. (Point to)

The twenty-four-inch gauge teaches us to make wise use of our allotted time on earth, in work and play, in devotion to God, and in service to his friends and brothers in freemasonry. With the important caveat *"without detriment to ourselves or connections"*. so, displaying that balance of mind.

The common gavel is the voice of conscience, which is ever ready to prompt us in the right course of action, and knock off all vain and unbecoming thoughts.

The chisel points out to us that we should continually educate ourselves not only in Freemasonry but all aspects of life, so that the mason is able to contribute and participate in the society he resides in. It is not enough to be a great ritualist and recite, passages perfectly, but to let the message contain therein shape us from within to be more, empathetic companionate and respectful members of society and to each other.

So, the working tools of an Entered Apprentice Freemason teaches him to balance his material life, to conqueror his lower nature and will, by listening to his conscience and raising his higher nature by devotion to God and his family, educating himself both in secular studies and spiritual, to strength his lot in live, and in service to his friends, brothers, and society in general.

Salute WM

Narrator – Russell – Before we get to the next Scene while our candidate is being restored to his personal comforts, we will take a short comfort break. And try to answer any questions

Narrator – Russell – Act 3- Presentation of the White Gloves to be delivered by W/ Bro

JD escorts NB from the South East to Infront of the Secretary's Desk

17. Presentation of the White Gloves (Delivered by JW or Open)

Salute WM

I congratulate you brother upon being admitted into our beloved order". Shake New Brothers Hand

If JW is delivering then use this phrase "A*s the ostensible Steward of the Lodge, and therefore responsible to ensure that every brother is suitably attired when in the*

Lodge I have been entrusted by the Worshipful Master, with the duty of presenting to you in Open Lodge your White Gloves, which you will now put on.

If a brother is delivering then say "*I have been entrusted by the Worshipful Master, with the duty of presenting to you in Open Lodge your White Gloves, which you will now put on.*

The first record of wearing of White Gloves dates back to 15 January 1559, when records of the 'Kilwinning Lodge' in Scotland stated that a brother on his initiation was presented with a pair.

Tolstoy's novel "War and Peace" (1869) says, "the newly-obligated brother was then invested with a white apron, and received a trowel, and three pairs of white gloves, two pairs for himself, and one pair for the lady he most esteemed, after which the Master explained their symbolic meaning to him."

Symbolically the White gloves denote innocence and purity. You may recall that, the Brother Senior Warden passed a remark "that the Apron is a Badge of Innocence and a bond of friendship", so blended with the purity of these white gloves, may you ever be the symbol of purity of action, rectitude of conduct, and nobler deeds.

You will henceforth wear these White Gloves at all future meetings of the lodge, save on the subsequent occasion when you, are yourself, again are a Candidate in the Superior Degrees in your Masonic career.

So, when you are about to enter a Lodge, your last duty is to put on your White gloves and you will be reminded of this day, of which you will have many happy memoires."

<u>History</u>

Operative masons wore gloves to protect their hands, and these were regularly supplied by their employers, for example in 1423 the York Minster supplied ten pair of gloves to masons at a cost of 6p in today's money.

In the early days the Entered Apprentice was expected to clothe the lodge with gloves and aprons, and make a donation to charity. Rev James Anderson's Constitutions of 1723, article VII, stipulates that *'Every new Brother at his making is decently to cloath the Lodge, that is, all the brethren present and to deposit something for the relief of indigent and decay'd Brethren".*

The Presentation of the White Gloves has been largely discarded in modern freemasonry. But, in the Netherlands the presentation of white gloves remains. The new made brother is given a pair of white gloves to wear. He is also presented with a pair of lady's gloves, which he is directed to hand to her whom he considers most worthy to receive them.

Salute WM

Narrator – Russell - - Presentation of the First-Degree Tracing Board delivered by

DC with ADC request all EA to form an arc on the floor of the lodge

Deacons escort all EA in attendance to form an arc starting at the WM pedestal arcing towards the Secretary's Desk and finishing at the SW pedestal, our "Candidate is in the middle under the "G"

18. First Degree Tracing Board

Salute WM

The usages and customs among Freemasons have ever borne a near affinity to those of the Ancient Egyptians. Their philosophers, unwilling to expose their mysteries to vulgar eyes, concealed their particular tenets and principles of policy and philosophy under hieroglyphical figures and expressed their notions of government by signs and symbols which were communicated to their Priests or Magi alone, who were bound by oath never to reveal them.

Pythagoras seems to have established his system on a similar plan and many others of a more recent date have copied his example. Masonry, however, is not only the most ancient, but the most honourable Institution that ever existed; every character or emblem here depicted serves to inculcate the principles of piety and virtue. let me first direct your attention to the form of the lodge which is an oblong or parallelopipedon; in length from E to W, in breadth between N and S, in depth from the surface of the earth to the centre, and even as high as the Heavens.

A Freemason's lodge is described as being of such vast dimensions to shew the universality of the science; likewise, that a Freemason's charity should know no bounds save those of prudence.

Our lodges stand on holy ground because the first lodge was consecrated on account of three grand offerings thereon made, which met with Divine approbation.

Our lodges are situated due E and W because all places of Divine worship, as well as Freemasons' regular, well formed, duly constituted lodges are, or ought to be, so situated; for which we assign three Masonic reasons. First, the Sun, the Glory of the lord, rises in the E and sets in the W; secondly, learning originated in the E and thence spread its benign influence to the W; there is likewise a third, last and grand reason, which however, is too long to be given here.

Our lodges are supported by three great pillars, which are called Wisdom, Strength, and Beauty; Wisdom to contrive, Strength to support, and Beauty to adorn; Wisdom to conduct us in all our undertakings, Strength to support us under all our difficulties, and Beauty to adorn the inward man. These three great pillars are emblematical of those three Divine attributes and further represent Solomon King of Israel, Hiram King of Tyre, and Hiram Abiff; Solomon King of Israel for his wisdom in building, completing, and dedicating the Temple at Jerusalem to God's service; Hiram King of Tyre for his strength in supporting him with men and materials, and Hiram Abiff for his curious and masterly workmanship in beautifying and adorning the same. But as we have no noble orders of Architecture known by the names of Wisdom, Strength and Beauty, we refer them to the three most celebrated which are the Ionic, Doric, and Corinthian.

The covering of a Freemason's Lodge is a celestial canopy of divers colours, even the Heavens. The way by which we, as Freemasons, hope to arrive there is by the assistance of a ladder, in Scripture called Jacob's ladder. It has many staves or rounds which point out as

many moral virtues. The three principal ones are Faith, Hope, and Charity; Faith in T.G.A.O.T.U., Hope in Salvation, and to be in Charity with all men.

This ladder, which reaches to the Heavens, rests on the V. of the S.L., because by the doctrines contained in that Holy Book we are taught to believe in the wise dispensation of Divine Providence, which belief, strengthens our Faith and enables us to ascend the first step. This Faith naturally creates in us a Hope of becoming partakers of the blessed promises therein recorded, which Hope enables us to ascend the second step. But the third and last, being Charity, comprehends the whole, and the Freemason who is in possession of this virtue in its most ample sense, may justly be deemed to have attained the summit of his profession, figuratively speaking, an ethereal mansion, veiled from mortal eyes by the starry firmament, emblematically depicted in our Lodges by seven stars which have an allusion to as many regularly made Freemasons, without which number no Lodge is perfect, nor con any candidate be legally Initiated into the Order.

The interior of a Freemasons' Lodge is composed of Ornaments, Furniture, and Jewels. The Ornaments are the Mosaic Pavement, the Blazing Star, and the Indented or Tessellated Border; the Mosaic Pavement is the beautiful flooring of the Lodge, the Blazing Star, the Glory in the centre, and the Indented or Tessellated Border, the skirtwork round the same.

The Furniture consists of the V. of the S.L., the Cs. and S.; the Sacred Writings are to rule and govern our faith and on them we obligate our candidates for Freemasonry; so are the Cs. and S., when united, to regulate our lives and actions. The Sacred Writings are derived from God to man in genera I, the Cs. belong to the Grand Master in particular, and the S. to the whole Craft.
Of the Jewels, three are movable and three immovable. The movable Jewels are the S., the L., and the P.R.; the S. is used by operative Masons to try and to adjust rectangular corners of buildings and to assist in bringing rude matter into due form; the L., to lay levels and prove horizontals; and the P.R., to try and to adjust uprights while fixing them on their proper bases; they have likewise a moral tendency. They are ca lied movable Jewels because they are worn by the Master and his Wardens and are transferable to their successors on nights of Installation. The Master is distinguished by the Square., the S.W. by the Level., and the J.W. by the Plumb. Rule

The immovable Jewels are the Tracing Board, the Rough and Perfect Ashlars. The Tracing Board is for the Master to lay lines and draw designs on, the Rough Ashlar for E.A. to carve, mark, and indent on, and the Perfect Ashlar for the more experienced workman to try and to adjust his Jewels on. They are called immovable Jewels because they lie open and immovable in the Lodge for the brethren to moralise on.

In all regular, well formed, and duly constituted Lodges there is a point within a circle round which the brethren cannot err. This circle is bounded between N and S by two grand parallel lines, the one representing Moses, the other K.S.; on the upper part of this circle rests the V. of the S.L. unfolded, supporting Jacob's ladder, and were we as conversant with the doctrines contained in that Holy Book and adherent thereto as those two grand parallels were, it would bring us to Him who will not deceive us, neither will He suffer deception. In passing round this

circle we must of necessity touch on both those parallel lines, likewise the V. of the S.L., and while a Freemason keeps himself thus circumscribed it is impossible for him to err.

The word Lewis denotes strength and is here depicted by certain pieces of metal, which, when dovetailed into a stone, form a cramp and enables the operative Mason to raise great weights to certain heights with little encumbrance, while fixing them on their proper bases. Lewis likewise denotes the son of a Freemason, whose duty to his parents is to bear the heat and burden of the day, from which they, by reason of their age, should be exempt, and to assist them in time of need and thereby render the close of their days happy and comfortable; his privilege for so doing is that of being made a Freemason before any other person, however dignified.

Pendant to the corners of the Lodge are four tassels, meant to remind us of the four cardinal virtues, namely, Temperance, Fortitude, Prudence, and Justice, the whole of which, tradition informs us, were constantly practised by a majority of our ancient Brethren.
In conclusion, let me remind you that the distinguishing characteristics of a good Freemason are Virtue, Honour, and Mercy, and should they be banished from all other societies, may they ever be found in a Freemason's breast.

Salute WM

DC request all EA to be seated

Epilogue (Narrator)

In conclusion, the first act of the ceremony is designed to prepare the candidate to be restored to light, by seeking the light with his heart and preparing his mind, for higher thoughts.

The second act reveals the light, provides him with the necessary attire and tools, along with instructions on how to use them to retain and increase the light within him, so as to elevate himself spiritually before his God, and be of service to humanity.

Wilmshurst sums it up nicely in his book The Ceremony of Initiation *"The Apprentice stage of Masonry is, therefore, one of purification, education and self-control, which every brother must work out and live out for himself. No amount of book knowledge or instruction from others can teach him what can be learned only from his own experience and effort".*

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